Companion — flock user guide

This module changes what a fleet of BirdDog Play NDI/SRT decoders is playing, from one surface, through flock.

The README covers installing the module. This guide is about building a surface with it, and what a group button actually does to the room.

> **Before you rely on this:** a group action writes to **real hardware, lots of boxes at a time**. Each one re-routes what a physical decoder is putting out of its HDMI, which may well be a screen someone's watching. There's no confirmation step. Rehearse the page.
>
> This module was built with AI assistance, directed and reviewed by a human author.

Connecting

flock's web server, port **8080** by default. Leave the password blank unless flock was started with `[web].admin_password`.

> **flock's brute-force lockout is process-wide, not per client.** Repeated wrong attempts from Companion lock the web UI out too, so a mistyped password here takes away the tool you'd use to find out what's wrong.

Set the poll interval deliberately

There are **two very different kinds of read** behind this module, and only one of them is free:

	Comes from	Cost
Which decoders exist, and their tags	flock's WebSocket, pushed on change	free
Online, resolution, bitrate, what it is playing	one HTTP request from flock **to every decoder**	not free

That's why the status poll defaults to something slow enough to leave a fleet in peace rather than something that feels snappy.

- **5 s** suits a monitoring page.
- **0** turns polling off altogether. Actions still work, and each one refreshes once by itself, which makes it the right setting for a surface that fires takes rather than watches status.

A fast interval means constant traffic to real decoders, all day.

Group takes are the point

flock is there to change lots of decoders at once. A group action writes to **every decoder carrying that tag**.

The tag dropdown shows how many decoders are in the tag. Check it before you fire.

And use the right feedback on group buttons: **"Every decoder with a tag is playing the same source"**, not the per-decoder one. A take that reached three decoders out of four shouldn't look like a success. That partial landing is the failure that deserves a light of its own, and it's why the generated group preset uses the all-members feedback.

When a group action fails on some decoders, each failure is logged on its own rather than everything collapsing into one "failed", so the log tells you *which* box didn't take it.

"Online but no picture"

This is the state an operator most wants a light for, and the one "is it online?" can't see: **the box is up and answering, and no video is arriving.**

It has its own feedback, and the generated per-decoder preset shows it **in red over the online green**, so a decoder that's technically fine and showing nothing doesn't look healthy.

Offline means offline

Unlike my other modules, **this one marks a decoder that stops answering as offline rather than keeping its last known value.** Here that's actual information about a physical box, and a decoder showing green while it's unplugged is worse than no light at all.

flock is connected covers a different case, where the module knows nothing at all. Put both on the page, because they send you looking in different places.

NDI source names are free text

The hardware itself has no picker for discovered sources on that field, so you type the source name rather than choosing it.

Log the NDI sources flock can see is there to help you look it up: run it, read the log, copy the name. It doesn't fill a dropdown, and it can't.

Building a surface that fails safe

1. **Group buttons with the all-members feedback**, never the per-decoder one.
2. **Check the tag counts** in the tag dropdown before a show.
3. **Online-but-no-picture** on every per-decoder tile.
4. **flock is connected** somewhere you can see it, so a dead module doesn't look like a healthy fleet.
5. **Poll interval at 0** on a takes-only surface, 5 s on a monitoring wall, and no faster.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause
A group button went green but one screen is wrong	The per-decoder feedback is on the button. Use the all-members one.
Status never updates	Polling is off (interval 0). Actions still refresh once each; add *Refresh status now*.
Constant traffic to the decoders	The poll interval is too fast. Each poll hits every box.
A decoder shows online with a black screen	That is the online-but-no-picture state — add its feedback.
The web UI locked me out after using Companion	The lockout is process-wide. Fix the password in the connection config.
Source name does nothing	It is free text and must match exactly. Run *Log the NDI sources flock can see*.

See also

- README: installing, and the full list of actions, feedbacks and variables
- `companion/HELP.md`: the same material, in Companion's help panel